

Leadership by Example



If there ever was a time that is both interesting and challenging for corporate leaders, it is now. Interesting, because of the winds of change sweeping through the business-, economic- and technological landscape, where leaders who are nimble can grab opportunities for growth. And challenging, because seldom has such a cocktail of events manifested itself at the same time—geopolitical tensions and wars, the tendency of global economies to turn more inward-looking, supply chain problems, and more. Just as the world was recovering from the crippling effects of the pandemic, the Russia-Ukraine war and the Israel-Hamas face-off meant that CEOs had to go back to the drawing board, regroup and come up with new strategies.

Amidst all this, India, the world's fastest-growing major economy, stands out as a beacon of hope. The government is pushing economic growth and front-loading capex to ensure private investment is crowded in, and the robust domestic market provides companies a massive cushion when overseas markets turn challenging. Not surprisingly, PwC's recent 27th Annual Global CEO Survey showed that India has risen to No. 5 as an investment destination for global CEOs, up from No. 9 in 2023. Nine out of 10 Indian CEOs believe the country's economy will improve, and seven out of 10 feel confident about their companies' revenue prospects. But, there is a need for constant reinvention. The advent of Generative AI, cybersecurity risks, climate change and health risks are key challenges. It is against this background that we bring you this year's *BT*-PwC India's Best CEOs list—a line-up of India's sharpest and most effective business leaders who have guided their companies through choppy waters and remained resilient in the wake of unforeseen challenges. The winners were picked by a jury chaired by Uday Kotak, Founder and Director, Kotak Mahindra Bank; Rajat Dhawan, Senior Managing Partner, McKinsey & Company in India; Ramnath Krishnan, MD, ICRA; R.M. Vishakha, MD & CEO, IndiaFirst Life Insurance; and Amit Tandon, Founder & MD, Institutional Investor Advisory Services.

We have also introduced seven new categories this year—Unicorn, PSU, Resilient CEO, Glocal CEO, Travel, Best Deal and Clean Energy. While Sunil Bharti Mittal, Founder & Chairman of Bharti Enterprises, was chosen as the Business Icon of the Year for how he has grown Bharti Airtel despite heavy odds, the jury conferred the Lifetime Achievement Award on Dr Prathap C. Reddy, Founder Chairman of Apollo Hospitals, for his enormous contribution to healthcare in India. The jury also decided to give a special Impact Leader of the Year award to India's G2o Sherpa Amitabh Kant for the brilliant way in which he guided India's G2o presidency last year. The stories of all the winners demonstrate the indomitable entrepreneurial spirit that defines the Indian business landscape. More power to them. **BT**

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